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Putin sorry but shirks blame in plane crash

Evidence points to Russia's downing of the craft, White House says

BY MARY ILYUSHINA

Russian President Vladimir Putin has apologized to the leader of Azerbaijan for the crash of a passenger airliner following an unspecified "tragic incident" in Russian airspace, the Kremlin said Saturday.

Neither Putin nor his government has taken responsibility for downing the Azerbaijan Airlines flight that crashed in Kazakhstan on Christmas Day. The White House said Friday that evidence suggests the plane was brought down by Russia.

Thirty-eight passengers and crew were killed; 29 survived.

Azerbaijan Airlines Flight 8243 departed from Baku, the capital of Azerbaijan, with 67 people on board shortly before 8 a.m. local time Wednesday, for Grozny, the capital of Chechnya in Russia. It was diverted from Grozny mid-flight and later crashed near Aktau in southwestern Kazakhstan, about 270 miles east across the Caspian Sea.

Putin and Azerbaijani President Ilham Aliyev discussed the repeated attempts by the on-schedule plane to land at the Grozny airport, the Kremlin said in a summary of the call. Putin told Aliyev that the area had been attacked by Ukrainian drones that activated Russian air defense.

"Vladimir Putin apologized in connection with the fact that the tragic incident occurred in Russian airspace, and once again expressed deep and sincere condolences to the families of the victims, wished a speedy recovery to the injured," the Kremlin said.

The Azerbaijani government, in its own readout of the call, said Putin "apologized for the fact" that the Embraer-190 "was subjected to external physical and technical impact in Russian airspace, which resulted in a tragic incident."

Aliyev, the Azerbaijani government said, "emphasized that there are numerous holes in the fuselage of the plane, passengers and crew members, while still in the air, were injured by foreign particles that pierced the skin and entered the cabin of the plane, and that the testimonies of the surviving flight attendants and passengers of the plane con-

SEE CRASH ON A15

Joe Biden's lonely battle to sell his vision of American democracy

Earlier this year, Rep. James E. Clyburn met President Joe Biden at the White House to deliver a stern message: Biden had to find a way to revitalize his flagging campaign. Clyburn, who had been pivotal to Biden's 2020 victory, also made a confession about his own long-standing belief that substance is more important than style in politics.

"I have come to the conclusion in recent days that I'm wrong about that," the South Carolina Democrat, 84, remembers telling Biden. "The new environment that we currently live in — style seems to carry the day more than substance."

"Your style," he told the president, "does not lend itself well to the environment we're currently in."

BY TYLER PAGER

How Biden Leads: This story is part of a four-part series scrutinizing Biden's leadership style and the way he ran the most complex government in the world. The first three installments were published while Biden was seeking a second term.

Clyburn's conclusion — which was shared by anxious Democrats in the months before the president ended his reelection bid — undermined Biden's theory of presidential leadership. After Donald Trump's ascent, Biden believed that he just needed to show Americans that traditional democracy still worked — by listening to experts, working with Republicans, passing popular policies — and

voters would rally around him.

He succeeded in Phase One of his plan, enacting legislation, much of it bipartisan, to reshape the nation's infrastructure, revive the semiconductor industry and fight climate change. But Phase Two never happened. The truth of Biden's presidency is that he failed in what was by his own account his most important mission: making

SEE BIDEN ON A8

THE TAKEOVER



NADÉGE MAZARS FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Cocaine boom defies years of work

The drug lord had already escaped the law in three countries, and he planned to do it again.

In less than a decade, Dritan Rexhepi had built a smuggling business that ran from the fields of Colombia to the ports of Ecuador and on to the streets of Europe, Italian and Latin American investigators said, rivaling the influence of Mexico's powerful cartels. His brand, carved into cocaine packages, was "Bello" — beautiful.

The Albanian's rise from gunman in his home country to transatlantic kingpin is part of a global explosion in the cocaine industry, a trade that is far bigger and more geographically diverse than at any point in history. South America now produces more than twice as much cocaine as it did a decade ago. Cultivation of coca

Despite tens of billions spent in drug war, the trade is far larger and has gone global

BY SAMANTHA SCHMIDT, ARTURO TORRES AND ANTHONY FAIOLA
IN GUAYAQUIL, ECUADOR

Colombian police Lt. Jonnathan Gil inspects types of coca: in his right hand, a branch of the *Erythroxylum novogranatense* type, and in his left, the *Erythroxylum coca* type.

crops in Colombia, the origin of most of the world's cocaine, has tripled, according to U.S. figures, and the amount of land used to grow the drug's base ingredient is more than five times what it was when the infamous drug lord Pablo Escobar was killed in 1993.

And production keeps soaring. A record 2,757 tons of cocaine was produced worldwide in 2022, a 20 percent increase over 2021, according to this year's global drug report from the U.N. Office on Drugs and Crime.

"It's going up and up and up," said Thomas Pietschmann, a research officer at the UNODC. "A few years ago, people were

SEE COCAINE ON A12

Cocaine superhighway: A South American waterway is a primary artery to Europe. **A10**

Aides say bluster part of Trump's bigger plan

Critics worry comments about Panama, Canada could hurt relationships

BY JACQUELINE ALEMANY AND CAT ZAKRZEWSKI

In the past several weeks — and before he has been sworn in for his second term — President-elect Donald Trump has threatened trade wars with both of the United States' closest neighbors, mused about taking over Greenland, blustered about bringing the Panama Canal back under American control and suggested making Canada the 51st state.

Less than a month before his inauguration, Trump — who vowed to end foreign wars and made "peace through strength" a rallying cry of his 2024 presidential campaign — is crafting an "America First" foreign policy defined by antagonism toward U.S. allies and adversaries alike, centered around dreams of territorial expansionism, and channeled through the president-elect's braggadocio.

Trump's pre-presidency tactics regarding Greenland, the Panama Canal and the United States' closest neighbors aren't likely to result in massive change. Canadians and their political leaders are unlikely to prove receptive to dissolving their country, and U.S. lawmakers have not broadly expressed willingness to absorb Canada as a new state. Greenland's prime minister has said the island is not for sale, and Panamanian President José Raúl Mulino has said that "every square meter of the Panama Canal and its adjacent zone belongs to Panama and will remain so."

For any other modern president — especially one who campaigned on ending wars, not starting them — threatening to encroach on allies' sovereignty would be extremely unusual. But U.S. foreign policy during Trump's first term was marked by near-constant departures from diplomatic conventions and prior international commitments and defined by unpredictable and at times hostile political and economic brinkmanship with traditional partners and enemies across the globe. For Trump, training his imperial instincts on some of the United States' closest partners advances a version of that same scattershot foreign policy he pursued during his first term, when he sought to forcefully promote American interests on the global stage with little regard for borders or delicate international relationships.

Trump's team insists that his recent comments are part of a broader strategy.

"World leaders are flocking to the table because President Trump is already delivering on his promise to Make America Strong Again," Trump transition spokes-

SEE TRUMP ON A4

Plan for TikTok: Trump seeks ban delay so he can "save" the app. **A3**

A spate of abandoned newborns unsettles Texas

Desperation is a common thread. Critics cite strict abortion ban, poor health care for women.

BY MOLLY HENNESSY-FISKE
IN HOUSTON

The call came in on the fire truck's radio on a blazing hot summer afternoon: "Baby in a dumpster."

"It didn't specify alive or dead," Patrick Pequet remembers.

He and fellow firefighters arrived within minutes, pulling into the rear parking lot of an apartment complex in the southwest quadrant of this sprawling city. Police were already there, as were several residents who had frantically summoned them, standing near a blue dumpster crowded by discarded boxes,

scattered trash and garbage bags.

In one of those bags, a baby had been crying. Now, only silence.

"They didn't want to touch it," Pequet says. "It was very still."

A quarter-century ago, prompted by a spate of abandoned babies in Houston, this state became the first in the country to pass a safe haven law allowing parents to relinquish newborns at designated places — without questions or risk of prosecution.

Yet "Baby Moses" surrenders remain rare in Texas, and another series of abandoned infants

SEE TEXAS ON A6



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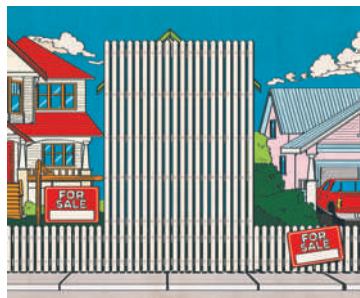
METRO
D.C.'s effort to redo the American University ANC election fails in court.

SPORTS
A highlight of the 10 moments of 2024? Olympic excellence.



ARTS & STYLE
Kanye West predicted pop's future. It's here, and he isn't a part of it.

OPINION
Post columnists answer questions they posed when the year began.



BUSINESS
A real estate battle over secretive off-market listings is heating up.

TRAVEL AND BOOK WORLD
The special sections are taking a break and will resume in the new year.

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